

951–960



This detail from the "Gateway of the Sun," a great stone doorway at Tiwanaku, is carved with a figure known as the Staff God.

THE PRE-INCA, ANDEAN CIVILIZATION OF TIWANAKU

declined precipitously in the second half of the 10th century. Sophisticated agricultural and irrigation techniques (see 741–50) had allowed Tiwanaku to support a **population** of up to 60,000 people, with up to **1.4 million** in the wider region, according to some estimates. A **prolonged drought** is believed to have been responsible for its **decline**, and archaeological evidence suggests that the main city was abandoned as citizens



Bronze Mirror

This intricately decorated mirror from the Song dynasty illustrates the artistic sophistication of China in this period.

retreated to smaller, rural settlements, and returned to a pre-urban lifestyle.

The **establishment of the Song dynasty** in China brought an end to the anarchy and warfare of the Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms era (see 901–10). Known as the **Northern Song** in its early stages because the capital was at Kaifeng in northern China, the dynasty was founded by **Zhao Kuangyin** (r. 960–76), who was a general under the Late Zhou, the last of the Five Dynasties. He dealt with the threat from external states such as the Khitan Liao (see 901–10), the Tangut kingdom of Xia Xia, a confederation of Tibetan tribes, and conquered several of the Ten Kingdoms to the south. Zhao used the civil service examination system to assert control over the military and centralize power.

Emperor Otto I, "the Great" (912–73), defeated the **Magyars** at the **Battle of Lechfeld** in 955. Since being displaced by **Byzantine–Bulgar conflict** (see 891–900), the Magyars had raided Frankish territories, reaching as far west as Aquitaine in 951. The son of Henry I (see 911–20), Otto vigorously asserted royal authority from his coronation in 936, gaining control of all the East Frankish duchies. His powerful army **ended the Magyar menace** and also defeated the **Wends**—tribes on the eastern border engaged in a long struggle to resist Frankish **colonization and Christianization**.

961–970



This detail from the imperial crown of Otto I shows the biblical figure King Solomon holding a scroll.



Viking sea routes

By the late 10th century, Viking seafarers had penetrated to every corner of Europe and beyond, reaching as far as Greenland in the north.

KEY

→ Viking expansionist exploration 8–10th centuries

THE POPE'S IMPERIAL CORONATION OF OTTO I

as emperor in 962 revived the **Carolingian Roman Empire** in the West. In 961, Otto made an expedition to Italy in response to a plea for protection from Pope John XII, and in Pavia he had assumed the Italian crown. The following year he went to **Rome** to receive the imperial crown and assert his authority over the fractious papacy. His son was crowned co-emperor as Otto II in 967.

In 965, the **King of Denmark, Harald Bluetooth**, converted to Christianity, and the **religion** spread rapidly through the Nordic region. Denmark had been forced to accept missionaries as the consequence of defeat by the East Frankish king, Henry I, in 933.

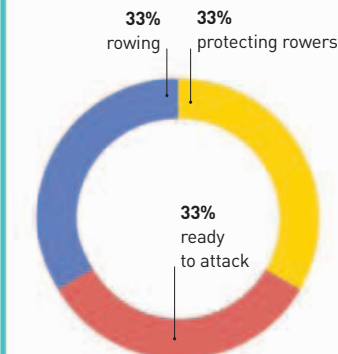
Further afield, Vikings continued to prosper as they penetrated into all parts of Europe.

The **death** of Byzantine emperor **Constantine VII** in 963 brought his infant son **Basil II** (958–1025) to the throne. In practice, authority was assumed by the general **Nicephorus Phocas**. As **Nicephorus II** (r. 963–969), he continued the restoration of the empire that had begun with the reconquest of Crete in 961, regaining Cyprus and Cilicia in 965, subduing the Bulgars in 966–69, and invading northern Syria in 969. That same year he was assassinated by his nephew, **John Tzimiskes**.

971–980

“A RECKLESS MAN BY NATURE [WHO]... ATTEMPTED UNUSUAL DEEDS”

Leo the Deacon on John Tzimiskes, late 10th century



Longboat crew in battle

By keeping part of the crew at the oars, Viking raiding parties maintained an aggressive posture without sacrificing mobility.

DURING HIS SHORT REIGN, JOHN TZIMISKES, nephew of Nicephorus II (see 961–70), won a string of victories. Having fought off a revolt by general Bardas Phocas in 971, Tzimiskes crushed a campaign by the **Kievan Rus** leader, Sviatoslav, and **conquered Bulgaria** as far as the Danube. In 972, he campaigned in the East, taking Edessa, Damascus, and Beirut, reaching the gates of Jerusalem in 976. He died suddenly that year.

In 980, the **Vikings** started **raiding** England again, though they suffered a reverse in Ireland, where Malachy II forced Viking Dublin to pay tribute.



- c. 950 Abandonment of Tiwanaku
- 951 Magyars raid as far west as Aquitaine
- 951 Emperor Otto I of East Francia invades Italy
- 954 Construction of Hindu Lakshmana temple at Khajuraho in central India
- 955 Battle of Lechfeld: Otto I defeats Magyars, who cease raiding and settle in Hungary
- 957 Byzantine general Nicephorus Phocas takes the city of Hadath, continuing Byzantine advance in Syria
- 960 Founding of Northern Song dynasty, China

- 962 Otto I crowned emperor in Rome
- 962 Ghaznavid dynasty founded in present-day Afghanistan
- 963 Death of Byzantine Emperor Constantine VII (b. 905); general Nicephorus Phocas becomes Emperor Nicephorus II
- 965 Khazars destroyed by Kievan Rus
- 967 Otto II crowned co-emperor to Otto I
- 969 Byzantine general John Tzimiskes assassinates his uncle to become emperor
- 969 First playing cards used in China
- c. 970 Beowulf first written down

- 972 Bulgar Khanate annexed by Byzantine Empire
- 973 Death of Otto I (b. 912)
- 973 Taira I overthrows the Rashtrakuta dynasty of central India, establishing the Chalukya dynasty
- 975 Beginnings of Hungarian state under Duke Geisa, who converts to Roman Catholicism
- 980 Vizier Al-Mansur becomes true power in Cordoba after death of al-Hakam II